



1952–2020 · Harvard Business School professor.

"Customers hire products to do a job."

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Christensen sought to explain a paradox: why great, well-managed companies fail. His answer was that the very practices that make incumbents successful — listening to their best customers — blind them to disruptive entrants rising from below.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Drawing on detailed industry histories (notably disk drives), Christensen built a theory distinguishing sustaining from disruptive innovation, later complemented by his causal theory of demand, Jobs To Be Done.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors Jobs To Be Done (Unit 1) and the Innovator's Dilemma and Disruption S-Curves (Unit 5), framing both how customers 'hire' products and how incumbents lose to disruptors.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His theories operationalise as a discipline of watching low-end and new-market footholds, and of designing around the customer's job rather than the product's features.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Scholars have questioned the predictive power and selective cases of disruption theory; Christensen acknowledged it is often misapplied to any new competitor rather than true disruptors.

ENDURING IMPACT

Disruptive innovation became one of the most influential — and most cited — ideas in modern management, reshaping how incumbents think about threats.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 1)

Russell Ackoff · Giant 1

John Boyd · Giant 2

Jan Carlzon · Giant 4

W. Chan Kim & R. Mauborgne · Giant 5

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Christensen, C.M. (1997) The Innovator's Dilemma. Boston: HBS Press.

Christensen, C.M. et al. (2016) Competing Against Luck. New York: HarperBusiness.